

Local Adoptions

According to Maryland Department of Human Services records, foster families permanently adopted three children from Cornucopia House. Two have since been unsealed. The third remains under seal until the adoptee reaches 18.

Unsealed: Lilia Bondarenko

Lilia Bondarenko died at the age of 15 in 2008. She was killed attempting to hop a Norfolk Southern freight train passing through Baltimore. The grisly state of her body initially provoked a homicide investigation before toxicology and forensics revealed she fell beneath the wheels while high.

The records were unsealed by detectives pursuing the case, but Lilia's adoptive parents, the Thompsons, had reported her missing multiple times throughout her adolescence. Interviews with the family, conducted by detectives attempting to write the case off as death by misadventure.

Lilia's struggles with bad behavior and addiction were worse than anything her adoptive parents had dealt with before. Her death was a serious tragedy to the family, and they made every attempt to find her when she ran away.

Parents situation??? No crime, no record I guess

Unsealed: Samuel Ball

Ball's record was unsealed by a previous investigation.

Samuel Ball was adopted by Clarence and Becky Mcleod in 2002 at age six. They changed his name to match theirs. They unofficially, illegally "returned" him to the state in 2005 at age nine by leaving him at a social services office.

The Mcleods claimed they were unfit to parent Samuel after he allegedly attempted to kill their biological daughter with a kitchen knife. The record was unsealed by an attorney hired by the parents as defense against prosecution for reckless abandonment. They lost the case. Each served six months in jail and paid a \$1,000 fine, and they temporarily lost custody of their biological daughter. They divorced in 2007. Becky Mcleod changed her name back to Marshall.

Mother: check fraud 2013-2020 (parole?) in Cumberland MD NBCI

Father: no fix address (RV living?) - Contact employer Gulf Quality Inc.

FORMER CASE WORKERS

Kerry Houghton, the victim of the latest murder at the excavation site, handled the case before being dismissed from her position in mid-2001. Her work record was spotty after that. She seemed to avoid any additional jobs involving her experience in educational psychology, children, or government work. It has been many years she since worked in such fields, so no one has correlated Houghton's former job with the geographical location of her killing. But it's only a matter of time.

Insurance records from Maryland DHS paint a haunting picture. Nearly everyone that ever worked on the Cornucopia House file is dead. There were three suicides by hanging among seven staff assigned to monitor the children from the 1970s to the 1990s. The only survivors past 2001 were Kerry Houghton and her predecessor, Gertrude Deropf.

Gertrude Deropf (née Price), widow of Franklin Deropf who "survived" head trauma in the Gulf War. He was checked into Charlotte's Rest Veterans Home located south of D.C., where he lived for almost a decade before succumbing to rapid developing complications with sepsis to the site of trauma. Interestingly enough, his spouse joined him in late 1998 when she abruptly developed symptoms of dementia and became unable to live assisted. Luckily for her, the veterans home allowed her extended stay and her address still seems to be there.

Ironically the same social services department that Gertrude once worked for had conducted bi-annual wellbeing interviews with her. Despite surviving a literal bullet to the head, Franklin maintained a better mental state compared to Gertrude until he passed away. He seems to have been present in the interviews as emotional support, but in fact, he was doing the talking. Gertrude went completely non-verbal about two years before he passed away in 2003. Franklin claims that their last days were rather peaceful and quiet, compared to the sour patches of their relationship in late 80s which led to Franklin seeking an overseas deployment.

In case one might expect recovery, there is no hope to be found in these files. Recent "interviews" conclude that Gertrude will likely remain catatonic until her passing. Veteran's home address: 311 Veterans Haven Drive, Charlotte Hall, MD 20622